not medicine but herbs that grow wild."

"Someone could tell her. Don't trust anyone."

If someone had reported Léa to the Lagerführer, she'd explain that since Maria sat next to her on the assembly line, she would have been at risk if the infection had spread, and that she'd given the Polish woman medicine to prevent it from spreading to herself.

The Meister circled the assembly line on his midday rounds, inspecting the quota targets of each women. Léa's jaw tensed as he hovered near Maria. She could tell from the way he stroked his moustache that he was counting the lenses and already knew Maria was short.

When the bell rang for lunch, Léa stood and stretched her arms and back, delaying her departure. She listened as the Meister approached Maria, blocking her from joining the others.

"Sabotage will not be permitted here. You will work during the lunch break," he ordered. "And if you don't make up the quota, you'll stay after your shift until you do. Understand?"

"*Ja*," Maria whispered, her voice weak.

Léa bristled. Every time a worker from the East—either Poland or Russia—got behind in their daily quota, they were accused of engaging in sabotage. This was how workers were sent off to harsh labor camps where they were worked to death. Not wanting to draw the Meister's wrath, she removed her apron and arranged the items in her work area until he left. Once he was out of sight, she put her apron on and continued to work.

Maria exchanged a look with Léa. "Go. I'll be fine."

"All the lenses I assemble over lunch, I'll add to your pile."

Maria's bony shoulders drew together as she leaned forward to add the tacky balsam to the edge of the lens. "*Mein Schutzengel*."

Léa smiled. Maria had called her a guardian angel.

"I'm not your *Schutzengel*, just a friend. And if the Meister insists you work tonight, I'll stay here too."

Maria turned to Léa. Her complexion suddenly whiter than the snow outside. "Thank you. I'm tired . . ." Her voice trailed off as she turned back to the machine.

"Have you not been sleeping well?" So many of the workers had become ill over the winter with insufficient rations to fight infections that lingered into the summer.